

Ruud, now back up to No. 7, cope with the ups and downs in the sport? In an interview with *Tennis Channel* before the Italian Open, he shared: "When you talk to someone — a psychologist, psychiatrist, or whoever — it helps. It's like personal training for your brain. You get personal training in the gym to work on your glutes or arms; I think talking to someone in this aspect is like personal training for your feelings." "With tennis, there is so much focus on what's happening on court," explained the 26-year-old, "whether you could have played your forehand or backhand better." Ruud elaborated, "It's also a very mental game, which can make it frustrating many times. I think the whole lifestyle of it all, with the travel we do and the day in, day out. There's not much rest." With renewed mental strength and a punishing clay-court game — particularly his vicious topspin forehand — it may take one of the Big Two to stop him.

No. 6 Novak Djokovic

The last of the legendary Big Three, Djokovic has astounded the tennis world by defying Father Time, just as Nadal and Roger Federer once did. But the GOAT turned 38 on May 22, and injuries, poor form, a severe lack of match play, along with waning motivation might prevent him from extending his men's record of 24 Grand Slam singles titles.

The Djoker last showcased his sustained brilliance at the Paris Olympics, where he seized the only prestigious title that had previously eluded him. He won every match in straight sets, outplaying Stefanos Tsitsipas, Musetti, and defeated Alcaraz (7-6, 7-6) in the gold medal match. In retrospect, the 2025 Australian Open may have been his last hurrah. There, he stopped Alcaraz 4-6, 6-4, 6-3, 6-4 — but it was a Pyrrhic victory as he tore his left hamstring and had to retire in the semifinal against Alexander Zverev.

As the European clay season began, former World No. 1 Andy Roddick, now a *Tennis Channel* analyst, remarked, "Is he what he was three years or 10 years ago? No. But who gives a s*#@! This guy is

Dip in form: After achieving a career-high No. 2 ranking in September 2022, Casper Ruud plunged to No. 15 in April this year. *AFP*



surviving. This guy can still win a Major." That confidence wasn't borne out, as Djokovic lost his third straight match — a 6-3, 6-4 debacle — to unheralded Matteo Arnaldi in Madrid. Not even former rival Andy Murray, who joined his coaching team for six months before they split on May 13, could help arrest the slide. "Trying to win a match or two, not really thinking about getting far in the tournament... It's a completely different feeling from what I had in 20-plus years of professional tennis," a humbled Djokovic acknowledged. "But that's the circle of life and of a career. Eventually, it was going to happen." Almost conceding Roland Garros, Djokovic skipped the Italian Open and took a wild card to enter the ATP 250 event in Geneva (instead of Hamburg, an ATP 500 one). If he reaches the quarterfinals in Paris, it will be a modest victory of sorts — and one that could help restore confidence ahead of Wimbledon, a tournament he has won seven times.

Best of the Rest: Jakub Mensik, Alexander Zverev, Francisco Cerundolo

Dark Horses: Lorenzo Musetti, Joao Fonseca, Arthur Fils, and Tommy Paul

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